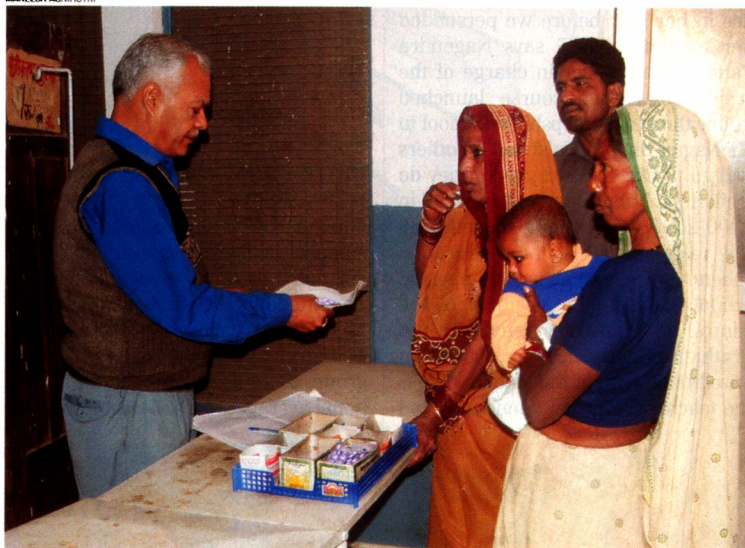




REPRIEVE FOR NOW: Vangeti B. Reddy and Kavitha at their farm

Reddy calls the "mother of all waivers that marks a new beginning" will benefit the couple as they need not repay a loan of Rs 35,000 drawn from the Andhra Bank. "This waiver, on top of free power raises hopes that farmers will get the importance they deserve," says Reddy, an award winning farmer. But for meaningful help, he believes the government should have an effective price and market mechanism to improve productivity. The couple grow paddy during the kharif season and fall back on drip irrigation to grow vegetables the rest of the year for which they earn little. These days they get just Rs 2 per kg for selling cabbage in the Hyderabad wholesale market, which is

MAMTESH AGNIHOTRI



more than 50 km away from their village. "Earnings from paddy enabled us buy a motorcycle 10 years ago," says Kavitha. Many others are luckier for they can hope for bigger write-offs but the waivers, which though provide relief, may not make a substantive difference. The write-off is a temporary gain and may lead to a decline in the number of suicides by farmers but only briefly, says secretary general of the Confederation of Indian Farmers' Association P. Chengal Reddy. Those who borrow from money lenders at rates as high as 36 per cent, however, do not benefit from the mega deal.

by Amarnath Menon

AILING SCHEME

Shishendi, Uttar Pradesh

NATIONAL RURAL HEALTH MISSION

Budget allocation for 2008-09

Rs 12,050 crore

DISTINCTION

PASS

FAIL

The Community Health Centre (CHC) in Mohanlalganj, Lucknow, may match any district hospital in its building, modern operation theatre and senior doctors performing duty round the clock, but the National Rural Health Mission (NHRM) is yet to achieve its desired results in rural areas. Initiated nationwide in 2005, but implemented in the state

PAYMENT PAIN

Godamakunta, Andhra Pradesh

ONE-TIME WRITE OFF FOR FARMERS

Budget allocation for 2008-09

Rs 16,000 crore

DISTINCTION

PASS

FAIL

For Vangeti Bhoopal Reddy, 45, and wife Kavitha, 37, who hold more than 5 acre of land in the Ranga Reddy district, the Union government's farm waiver scheme is a welcome reprieve. What state Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara

HEALTH UNWISE: Primary Health Centre in Shishendi near Lucknow

only by end 2006, it aims at strengthening primary and tertiary level hospitals. Take the primary health centre at Shishendi, just 30 km from Lucknow. It's been 25 years since it came up, but it does not have a single bed. The labour room has been in operation only for three months. The NHRM had introduced the Janani Suraksha Yojana in 2006, providing Rs 1,400 for every new mother and Rs 250 for every associated health activist (one for every 1,000 people) for bringing a delivery case to the PHC. Even then there have been only six deliveries here this year. by Subhash Mishra